cultural patronage, one of the spheres of activity identified as integral to the actuation of Perso-Islamic kingship during the twelfth century (cf. Chapter 1). Stoking inter-*madhhab* competition most often resulted in the amassing of greater and more centralized power precisely in the hands of rulers and their agents.[21] In light of these established precedents of statecraft, it seems only natural that the Shansabanis – an emerging elite with a transregional presence in Gharjistan as early as the 1150s, followed by an even more consequential entrée into Ghazna by the 1170s – would also extend their patronage to other *madhhab*s precisely at the time of creating and consolidating their bases of power. Ghiyath al-Din's *official* shift from Karrami to Shafi'i affiliation in AH 595/1199 CE did not necessarily preclude patronage of other *madhhab*s beforehand, particularly by members of the sultan's family.

While Shafi'i and Hanafi theologians, jurists, and their followers tended to dominate politico-intellectual culture in the urban centers of eastern Iran, their influence did not extend with equal impact into more remote areas.[22] Since the time of Ibn Karram (d. AH 255/869 CE), the Karramiyya were much more adept than their urban colleagues at traversing the distance between intellectual–cultural centers and their hinterlands. According to Bosworth, Ibn Karram had proselytized in "Ghur, Gharchistan, and the countryside of Khurasan, denouncing both Sunnis and Shi'is alike, appealing especially to the peasants of those regions."[23] He eventually entered Nishapur with Gharjistani adherents already in tow.[24] In the early eleventh century, Sultan Mahmud Ghaznavi evidently first urged the Karramiyya (back) toward Ghur as he attempted to rid Nishapur of at least one of the contentious *madhhab*s that had made control of the city a constant balancing act among its prominent intelligentsia.[25] The Karramiyya's famed austerity underpinned their successful penetration of a difficult terrain like that of Ghur, relieved only by villages and mountainous strongholds rather than large commercial centers. Although many among the Sunni *madhhab*s considered the Karramiyya to be anthropomorphists – and thus outright heretical – the sect continued to hold some sway in the less trafficked reaches of Khurasan and elsewhere well into the late twelfth century.[26]

Among the agriculturalists, nomadic pastoralists, and other non-urban populations in regions such as Ghur, the Karramiyya simplified Islamic orthodoxy and preached direct and unschooled access to Islam. For example, the Karramiyya were known among Khurasan's more mainstream jurists for considering verbal utterance of *Shahada* as tantamount to full conversion. While the city-centered *madhhab*s vigorously criticized them for these practices, the latter actually garnered the Karramiyya enduring and loyal followers. Notwithstanding the orthodox *madhhab*s' objections to such simplifications,[27] such an easy distillation of Islam was conceivably more efficacious than rigidly complex teachings for the conversion of